Case Study: Special Teams to Special Leader at Under Armour

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The rise of Under Armour as a mission-driven and competitive brand did not occur merely by chance. The company's overnight publicity was a large result of the founder Kevin Plank's tight execution of marketing strategies to progressively build credibility and raise widespread awareness of their brand. Under Armour started off because Plank wanted to create technically engineered gear that could keep athletes comfortable with minimal sweat moisture during performance. Plank "maxed out his credit cards to launch Under Armour, running the initial operations out of his basement" (Barrabi 2020). Plank's motivation and dedication towards building the brand from scratch over time, paired with his ability to initially target specific smaller industries, led to immense fame and raised the integrity of Under Armour. The company "went mainstream in 1999 when the company landed a contract to outfit actor Jamie Foxx" (Barrabi 2020). The uniqueness of Under Armour's technologically advanced product, along with partnerships involving mainstream popular culture figures, drew attention from consumers and had positive financial impacts for the company. As Under Armour grew, Plank targeted more recognized athletes including Stephen Curry. He did this while continuing to produce innovative apparel, in order to keep up with competitors, such as Nike.

Kevin Plank's leadership quality that makes him such a successful leader is his resilience and how this coincides with his desire to overachieve expectations for the company. He mentions to CNBC that a guiding principle of the company's culture is to "over-promise and deliver" (Clifford 2016). Plank took many financial risks and used aggressive, but tailored, growth strategies in order to build up the credibility of Under Armour. Furthermore, Plank's management role in Under Armour's journey to success resides in his continuous product adaptations and competitive decision-making to foster a high performing environment. For

example, Plank took out an ad in 1999 in “an ESPN magazine to generate buzz but cost the company about all the money they had” (Persson 2024). In 2005, he “moved to footwear which proved to be a business wise decision as Under Armour’s quickest-growing category” (Persson 2024). Plank’s ability to manage the company through strategic growth decisions and tailor the company’s products to best meet the demand of the global marketplace was incredibly vital towards Under Armour’s growth and success. Plank uses people skills to foster relationships that involve trust and communicating in order to build a mission for the brand as its identity which people involved can relate to. He mentions how “in growing you can’t invent the people who will stay the extra 3 or 4 hours to make sure a shipment goes out” (SmartCEO 2013). Plank’s technical and conceptual skills demonstrate his knowledge of the market and how he strategically has designed products that best meet customer’s demand at that specific time in the industry. These characteristics display high level decision-making skills of Plank which he shows while adapting in a competitive market to best drive revenues for Under Armour

With the rising competitiveness of Nike and Adidas, alongside the emergence of brands, I do not think Under Armour is positioned very well in the global marketplace. Under Armour’s large presence in female leggings has been affected because new brands such as Lululemon and Athleta, have “caught the attention of female shoppers” (Lussier 2024). During the COVID era, online shopping became very common and Under Armour has done very little to give themselves the competitive edge over other big-name brands. To ensure competitiveness in the international sport apparel business, they should promote their products in more specific, higher-growth industries with lots of consumer needs. This would give them the opportunity to receive more brand recognition, product demand, and generate revenues for the company.

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